

Building Trust + Vulnerability

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
For any mistake you make this week, apologize without a 'but.' Say: 'I'm sorry I [specific action]. Next time I will [new behavior].' Stop. No justification.	Have one 'rumbling' conversation using the script: 'I'm feeling [emotion] about [situation]. My story is [what I'm telling myself]. Can you help me understand your perspective?'	Dare to Lead: Brave Work, Tough Conversations, Whole Hearts (Brené Brown) — vulnerability, trust, and 'rumbling' with difficult topics

Core Concept

Brené Brown's research on vulnerability and courage challenges the most common leadership myth: that strength means never showing uncertainty, never admitting mistakes, and never letting others see you struggle.

In reality, leaders who model vulnerability — who admit they don't know, apologize cleanly, and 'rumble' with hard conversations rather than avoiding them — build the deepest trust. This is because vulnerability is contagious. When a leader shows up as a full human being, it gives others permission to do the same. Psychological safety — the research-proven foundation of high-performing teams — is built on exactly this.

Brown's BRAVING framework defines the components of trust: Boundaries, Reliability, Accountability, Vault (confidentiality), Integrity, Non-judgment, and Generosity. Leaders who embody these build teams that will follow them through the hardest challenges.

""Vulnerability is not weakness. It is our greatest measure of courage.""

— Brené Brown

Framework: BRAVING: The Anatomy of Trust

B — Boundaries: You respect my limits and ask when unsure.

R — Reliability: You do what you say you will. Consistently.

A — Accountability: You own your mistakes and expect the same.

V — Vault: You don't share information given in confidence.

I — Integrity: You choose courage over comfort. Values over expedience.

N — Non-judgment: I can share failures without fear of being judged.

G — Generosity: You extend the most generous interpretation of my intentions.

Score yourself 1-5 on each. Your lowest scores are where trust is most at risk.

Daily Practice

- Clean apology: When you make a mistake, say 'I'm sorry I [specific thing]. Next time I will [specific change].' No 'but', no explanation, no minimizing.
- Rumble starter: When you're in a conflict or a hard moment, say: 'I'm in a story right now. Can I share it and you tell me if I'm off base?'
- Trust audit: Pick one person. Go through each BRAVING element. Where is trust strong? Where is it fragile?
- Say 'I don't know': At least once this week, say 'I don't know the answer to that. Let me find out and get back to you.' Notice how it's received.

Leadership Scenarios

Scenario 1

You realize you gave your team incorrect information in a meeting last week that caused them to do unnecessary work.

Reflection: What is your clean apology? Practice saying it without qualifying it.

Scenario 2

You've noticed your relationship with a peer has become strained. You suspect there's an unspoken issue but neither of you has named it.

Reflection: How would you open a rumbling conversation?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: Where in the BRAVING framework is your trust with your team most fragile? What is one concrete action to strengthen it?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: What is one thing you've been avoiding saying to someone because it feels too vulnerable? What is the cost of continued silence?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: How comfortable are you with saying 'I was wrong'? What does your relationship with being wrong reveal about your leadership?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: